

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

Post-Modernism offers amusement

To review architecture today, you have to review the media too.

Last week's cover of *Time* magazine featured a photo of architect Philip Johnson, his eyes peering malevolently from

black frames, his figure darkly shadowed, holding up a cardboard cut-out model of his proposal for a new American Telephone & Telegraph office tower in New York.

"Is that Dracula?" asked my nine-year-old son, when he saw this cover.

I thought about that and said yes. All his life Johnson has shared Dracula's zest for self-dramatization. But he's become even more Transylvanian lately in the way he ingests new ideas from younger colleagues then promotes both the ideas and their authors to the world at large.

The AT & T, in case anyone doesn't know, or more likely doesn't care, is a 60-story office tower in the shape, roughly, of a grandfather's clock. It's a kind of huge corporate logo—no doubt AT & T will reproduce it on the letterhead—and is supposed to demonstrate several truths: That architects are free now to design buildings in clever or silly shapes, instead of sterile boxes; that ordinary people like things they can recognize; that buildings don't have to look all alike.

The AT & T has made a media event out of what had been, to date, an intense but rather small and elitist stirring of revolt among architects, a movement some have dubbed Post-Modernism (PM).

There's a lot of talk about PM but not much of it has been built. It's revealing that both *Time* and *Newsweek* had to run photos of the same few buildings and architects, including such minor efforts as a senior-citizens clinic in Indiana.

Some of the architects have built no more than a house or two, instead winning their degree of fame by successful manipulation of the major design schools, the New York museums, and the media.

As far as the built world is concerned, all the excitement has meant very little. PM has done far less than, say, the preservation movement or the suburban strip developer to shape the American environment, though it has attempted to piggyback on both of them.

Small as it is, though, and always running to catch up with events, PM is probably the right architecture for the Me Decade. As *Time*'s pictures show, every architect is doing his Own Thing—a glass



Architect Philip Johnson with model of his "grandfather clock."

(AP)

palace here, a Roman villa there, an homage to MacDonald's, some warmed up Cubism. A lot of it is witty and much is a deliberate media tease.

The PM architects now travel around with their sample cases like salesmen, appearing again and again at conventions and design schools. Their names are then traded, like baseball cards, among the trendy. "Here, I'll give you my Aldo Rossi for two Diana Agrests and a Gandelsonas."

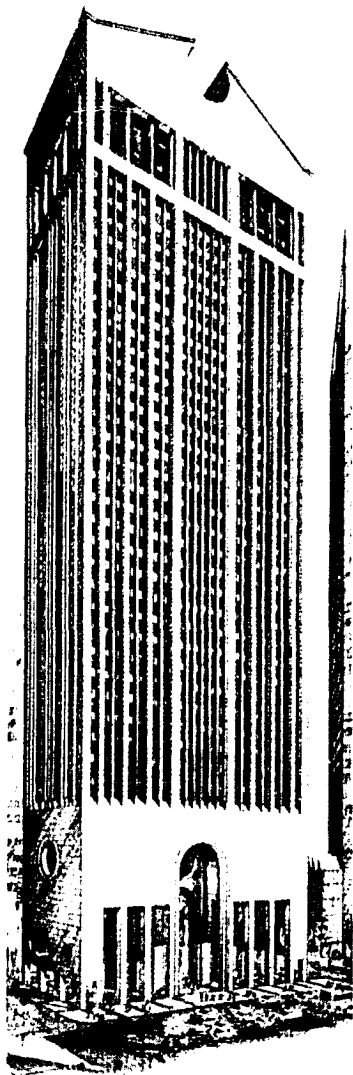
The fact that no one outside the design schools and the New York art scene has ever heard these names merely reinforces the security of membership in the identity group.

This odd, Rotarian side of the PM phenomenon reaches some kind of apogee in the movement's house organ, "Opposi-

tions," which has a regular feature called "Forum" consisting entirely of PM architects and their groupies standing around with martinis and chatting at meetings of Peter Eisenman's Institute for Architecture and Urban Studies in New York.

They look like Hef and the bunnies at the Mansion in one of those old spreads from *Playboy*.

Well, every profession has its mumbo jumbo, and the PMs deserve credit for bringing some amusement and ideas into an art that has long distrusted both. But I'd guess the PMs are in trouble now. In an avant-garde movement, a movement that relies as much as PM does on private signs, spells and secret handshakes, publication in slicks like *Time* and *Newsweek* is an early warning signal that it's time to move on to something newer. It will be fun to see what's next.



Architect's rendering of AT&T building.

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